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DIPLOMA THESIS PROJECT

Ontological Security of Bosnia



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Introduction

Research Target & Question

This project focuses on the ontological (in)security of Bosnia and how political speeches impact a state's identity. Under the framework set forth by Mitzen (2006, p. 344), states are inclined to seek ontological security, which requires a collective identity that constitutes a state identity. This identity is shaped both internally and externally, but the aim of this research is to understand how the political speeches of Bosnia's politicians shape the identity of the Bosnian state and whether this strengthens or weakens the state's ontological security. The working hypothesis for this project are as follows:

H_1 : There are unified concepts used by politicians in their speeches, regardless of party, that shape the Bosnian state identity.

H_2 : Ontological security shapes the political discourse amongst politicians.

Literature Review

One of the primary works used for conceptualizing the theory of ontological security in regard to states is Jennifer Mitzen's (2006) 2006 article titled *Ontological Security in World Politics: State Identity and the Security Dilemma*. This article expands upon Giddens' (2009) work focusing on how individual identities are constructed, and she applies the concept to state actors as a direct response realist theorists (Mitzen, 2006, p. 342-344). Mitzen's (2006) application of ontological security is largely covered in the following theoretical framework section, but it created a framework that has been cited in much of the literature on this topic, including much of the literature cited in this project.

There have been a few works that focus on ontological security on BiH, primarily Kočan's book *Identity, Ontological Security and Europeanisation in Republika Srpska* (2023), Lea David's article "Policing Memory in Bosnia" (2019), and Jagiełło-Szostak's "Srebrenica as a Marker of Memory in Bilateral Relations Between Serbia and Bosnia and Herzegovina in the Light of Ontological Security" (2025). A foundation of all of these works is a focus on the memory of BiH and how the Yugoslav Wars, in particular, shape the ontological security of BiH, regardless of ethnic divides (Kočan, 2023, p. 107-119; David, 2019, p. 216-220; Jagiełło-Szostak, 2025, p. 4-5). Despite many similarities in the theoretical approaches to Bosnian identity and ontological security, the subjects of them differ. Kočan (2023, p. 120-125) focuses on Bosnian Serbs, particularly in Srpska Republika, which provides insight into this particular enclave, which constitutes the second largest enclave, that also has a strong impact on foreign relations due to their ties with Serbia. As well focusing directly on Srpska Republika, he also elaborates on how the EU's attempts of *Europeanisation* have strained the ontological security in BiH and internal relations between parties (Kočan, 2023, p. 125-130) As well as substantial insight into the context regarding identity and ontological security of Republika Srpska, Kočan's (2023, p. 149-155) methodological approach follows a similar intended methodology as this project, revolving around content and

discourse analysis, providing a strong example of utilizing mixed methods of text analysis for analysis of ontological security and identity. David (2019, p. 216-220) and Jagiełło-Szostak (2025, p. 6-10) put more emphasis on memory in BiH, specifically how it is controlled and utilised, where David focuses on mnemonic politics as a way of shaping identities and ontologies, while Jagiełło-Szostak focuses specifically on the memory of the Srebrenica genocide and the role it plays on the collective memory, especially between the different ethnicities of BiH. Both approaches provide novel ways of working with the fragile and often contentious memories that stem from Balkan history, and particularly the events of the Second World War and the Yugoslav wars.

Due to the complexity of identity, particularly in the Balkans, further context and history was provided by a selection of works, the first of which is Todorova's *Imagining the Balkans* (2009). Todorova (2009, p. 18-19, 38-41) largely expands upon concepts such as *orientalism*, as coined by Said (1979), but does so in a Balkan context that emphasises the history of the region and the perception of the Balkans internally and externally. Her analysis targets the divisions within the understanding of the individual identities throughout the Balkans while also highlighting the *othering* carried out by "Western Europe" on the region as a whole, which often exoticizes the region and its peoples through terms such as *balkanization* or *balkanized* (Todorova, 2009, p. 33-35, 39-41). Another text that is highly influential in understanding the history of the Balkans, and particularly BiH is Andrić's novel *Na Drini Ćuprija* (*The Bridge on the Drina*) (1977). *The Bridge on the Drina* discusses the life in Višegrad in the 16th century, but it provides important insight into the mix of identities in BiH and its history (1977). As well as historical context of BiH and the region, the ethnic makeup of BiH also provides further detail that is of importance to this project. Bringa (2000) provides insight from an anthropological perspective regarding the mixed identities in BiH and the complex nature of Bosnian identity. Bringa's article provides first hand experiences and observations from mixed villages in BiH, and she describes many of the practices that allow for cohabitation, but still distinction between the different ethnicities throughout BiH (Bringa, 2000, p. 82-84). BiH has a complex history, which leads to a similarly complex mix of identities, which also provides a basis for this project, which focuses on politicians' attempts of both leveraging the differences of these identities for particular reasons and attempts to homogenize these identities into a common Bosnian identity as well.

Conceptual & Theoretical Framework

Planned Outline

The proposed outline for this thesis is as follows:

- Introduction
- Theoretical Framework
- Methodology
- Data

- Empirical Analysis
- Conceptual Analysis
- Conclusion

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